VITA Appointment Reservation System Project
CISC260: Individual Final Project

Background Information

The IRS's Volunteer Income Tax Assistance (VITA) and Tax Counseling for the Elderly (TCE) programs offer free basic tax return preparation to qualified individuals. The VITA program has operated for over 50 years, offering free tax help to people who generally make $82,000 or less, persons with disabilities, and limited English-speaking taxpayers who need assistance in preparing their own tax returns. In addition to VITA, the TCE program offers free tax help, particularly for those who are 60 years of age and older, specializing in questions about pensions and retirement-related issues unique to seniors. While the IRS manages the VITA and TCE programs, the VITA/TCE sites are managed by IRS partners and staffed by their volunteers who want to make a difference in their communities. Hartwick College served as an IRS VITA tax preparation site since AY2019. In the past 7 tax seasons, the program has served over 8,000 families in upstate New York and contributed nearly $ 6 million in economic impact to local communities.

Problem Statement

Hartwick VITA & TCE site needs a consistent reservation process for its campus and mobile tax-assistance sites. You will investigate the operation through provided documents and individual interviews with the site operations manager, develop a supported set of requirements, and use those findings in your individual final project.

Currently, clients arrange appointments through United Way 2-1-1, the local library, mobile-site partners, and the Hartwick phone line. These scheduling channels use a shared Google Calendar. However, broad editing access can make the schedule inconsistent. The program wants every channel to follow one reservation procedure, with preliminary screening before appointment selection.

The ordinary reservation process

1. The client completes the site screening questions.
2. The client must pass screening before selecting an appointment date and time.
3. The client selects an available appointment. Its site, date, and time must be clear.
4. The client provides a full name, phone number, and ZIP code.
5. The reservation is recorded through the common booking process, subject to available capacity and the household appointment rule.

A scheduling partner may enter the information while assisting a client. The same program rules must apply across the channels. The exact confirmation, correction, and exception procedures are your tasks to clarify with additional research and meetings with the operations manager.

The household appointment rule

Each household may make only one appointment. Clients may not reserve multiple appointments. The restriction applies across the program, including bookings made through different channels or at different locations.

Confirm what the program means by a household, what its appointment covers, how an existing household is recognized, and how cancellation or follow-up affects the rule. Do not independently reinterpret it as one appointment per site, one active appointment, or one appointment per tax year.

Service locations and recurring schedules

Location	Service days	One-hour appointment blocks	Daily capacity
Hartwick campus	Mondays and Tuesdays	6-7 p.m. 7-8 p.m.	16
Local library service	Saturdays	10-11 a.m.; 11 a.m.-noon 1-2 p.m.; 2-3 p.m.	32 per event
Norwich	Fridays in February	Same four daytime blocks	32
Utica	First Friday in April	Same four daytime blocks	32
Binghamton	Other Fridays in the operating season before April 15, excluding Norwich and Utica dates	Same four daytime blocks	32

Each hourly block has eight appointment slots. Each appointment lasts one hour and includes a brief taxpayer interview, tax preparation, and quality review. Friday and Saturday service has a noon-1 p.m. break. Its appointment start times are 10 a.m., 11 a.m., 1 p.m., and 2 p.m.

Screening and client information

Screening includes an income limitation. You can request the actual screening question list, income threshold and definition, and the meaning of a passing result. No dollar threshold or detailed screening decision table is established by this briefing. Record unanswered screening-policy questions for the interview.

Full name, phone number, and ZIP code are required contact fields. They do not, by themselves, establish a unique household identity. Any proposed additional information must have an agreed purpose in accordance with federal privacy law.

Your Tasks Now

Prepare questions about ordinary work, exceptions, responsibilities, and the qualities the future system must satisfy. Distinguish current practice from desired behavior and confirmed facts from your own assumptions. The operations manager may identify a genuine decision that remains open; document the decision needed and any proposal you make.

You are responsible for deriving functional requirements, business rules, and nonfunctional requirements from the evidence, which you collected from provided documents, meetings, and additional online research. Keep the source and rationale for each important requirement.